



MARKET IN PERU
Potatoes originated in the high Andes of South America. Many varieties of potato are still grown there, as this market scene shows.

Food from plants

PLANTS HAVE BEEN CULTIVATED as food crops for thousands of years. The earliest humans lived in nomadic groups, roaming the landscape in search of food. Eventually, these peoples settled down, and instead of collecting plant foods from the wild they began to cultivate them. When the time came to gather seeds to produce crops for the following year, they tended to take seeds from the healthiest plants. As they did this year after year, they began to produce better crop plants. Later, more deliberate efforts were made to improve crops by selecting and cultivating the strongest plants, and this process is continuing today. As farming settlements were established independently in different parts of the world, so different crops were cultivated in each place. This meant that when early travelers first visited distant continents, they found many new and exciting foods to bring home. The crops we eat today come from many different parts of the world.

KEPT IN THE DARK
If allowed to grow in the light, endive has a bitter taste. To reduce this bitterness, the plant is cut back to the ground and then allowed to regrow with almost no light. The pale, blanched leaves of the new endive shoot are far less bitter. If cultivated entirely in the light, the plant would look very similar to wild chicory.

Primitive form of corn plant and cob

Blanched shoot of cultivated endive

Modern corn cob

Wild chicory

PRIMITIVE CORN
Corn is a cereal: like wheat and rice, it is a member of the grass family. It was first cultivated in Central America, and some primitive forms of corn can still be found growing there. As a result of selective breeding, the size and shape of the modern corn cob have been increased.